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INDIA TODAY's annual survey of academic excellence, now in its 12th year, is one of our most eagerly-awaited issues. No matter what the news environment may be, our college special has always been one of the most widely-read issues in any year. Our rankings have become the benchmark for academic standards in India. So, there is greater onus on us to surpass expectations, to try to make the rankings more stringent. With every successive INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG annual survey of academic excellence, we try to ensure that our rankings are better, more rigorously-arrived at and more comprehensive.

Last year we expanded the survey from the top 10 colleges to the top 50 in the arts, science and commerce streams, and the top 25 in engineering, medicine and law. This year we have also included a city-wise ranking of top 10 colleges in six major metros to help students there make more informed choices.

The city-specific rankings led to a small shift in the ranking methodology. First, 400 experts were interviewed in order to shortlist the total of 1,400 colleges for the national-rankings round provided they met the minimum "national ranking cut-off" points as established by the survey team. The basket of 468 top colleges was then once again judged by another group of 400 experts and weighed statistically for determining their national perception scores. These experts also ranked the colleges in their respective cities.

A list of factual scores was then calculated using information about infrastructure, faculty and placements of the top 225 colleges. After four months of the survey, the final rankings were decided by applying a weightage of 70:30 to perceptual and factual scores. This year after the second level of testing, we were pleasantly surprised to find that the final rankings did not differ very significantly from those arrived at using the previous one-tier judging system.

While our rankings may be largely a perception-based score, it is important to note that this is the perception from within the Indian academic community. The few complaints we receive about the survey are from college principals who object to the perceptual ranking and ask why the survey cannot entirely be quantitative.

Other than the logistical hurdles of gaining access to and data from 18,000 colleges, it must be remembered that the UGC-backed National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC) has been unable to get more than 20 per cent of the colleges under its ambit in 14 years of its existence. In that context, our survey places before the college-goer a vast sweep of the best options available.

As competition increases, our colleges must move from being old institutions stuck in the past to dynamic centres of excellence. If our survey regularly forces introspection on our higher education, we will consider it a job well done.



Our June 2007 issue

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)

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